

Forbes.com, October 5, 2005

A Better Way To Search?

DAVID A ANDELMAN, executive editor, Forbes.com, speaks about the changes Yahoo! is incorporating into its search engine after they realised that they "are not the verb today"

I tried Yahoo!'s latest attempt to take on Google in search over the weekend, and I was underwhelmed.

Yahoo! and Google, the top two search engines, are just 6.7 percentage points apart, though it's true that the latest ComScore MediaMetrix numbers show that Google increased its market share in the past year by 1.2% to 37.3%, while Yahoo! shed 1%, coming in at 29.7%. Not too shabby, considering the two Big Kahunas of search together bring in two-thirds of all search traffic in the average month.

Still, Yahoo! wants more. "We are not the verb today," says Bradley Horowitz, director of media search for Yahoo! "We're not synonymous with search." The company is doing everything that the fertile imaginations of their software engineers can muster in order to persuade people to search with them first.

Before we get to Yahoo!'s "social search," let's step back and look at search in general. The goal is to find a particular Web site or factoid that answers a question or need. This

information is sitting somewhere on the billions of Web pages that exist in cyberspace, and the goal of search engine providers is to find the desired Web pages with the fewest clicks of the mouse.

The goal of any search engine is to become the destination of choice for these searchers, who will see the advertisements that make the search company rich every time a page is loaded. Yahoo!, like other Web portals, dropped the ball by not recognizing there was very big money to be made from this simple concept.

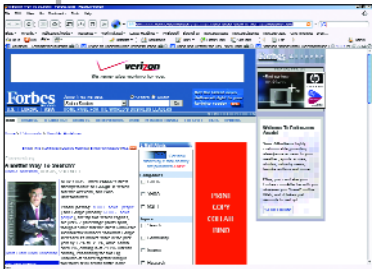
Google "crawled up on our backs," says Horowitz. Yahoo! helped give Google its legs by incorporating the search engine into its portal. "About two and a half years ago, we realized we made a mistake" by not recognizing the value of the search market sooner. So Yahoo! "bought up all of the remaining relevant companies" in the search market in order to catch up.

Moreover, with the growing conventional wisdom that search has turned into a commodity—albeit an essential one for any portal—Yahoo! also sought a better, and more expensive, way of distinguishing itself from Google, not to mention from Microsoft's MSN and InterActive's AskJeeves (which will soon be dropping "Jeeves"), which are in third and fourth place, respectively.

What Yahoo! has in mind is, at first blush, quite appealing: A search "community" that can create personal Web pages and link them directly with other searcher's pages. They call it MyWeb 2.0.

First, the idea behind MyWeb (now in beta version) is to create your own personal Web universe with the center being your own page, which includes all of the Web pages and links you've downloaded and stored there—basically, a snazzier set of bookmarks. In turn, these pages are searchable whenever you like.

For the complete column, visit <http://snipurl.com/digitoct1>



Variety.com, October 9, 2005

Old Media Reaches For Tech Tonic

"EVERYBODY IS NOW in competition with everyone else," Says Elizabeth Guider, executive editor of *Variety* in Los Angeles. Over the past 15 years, Guider has written extensively on entertainment and media subjects, and her questions are based on some firm grounds

Is it just me or has the pace of technological change picked up dramatically? The progeny of Hal the computer in Stanley

Kubrick's "2001" have become smarter, faster and more versatile than most of us probably were prepared for.

And am I wrong to think that every "old media" company is rethinking its business model as a result?

Not a day goes

by but some media company doesn't pitch out its rule book or take a page out of a rival's playbook. The upshot: Everyone is trying to eat everyone else's lunch. I guess that's what they mean by convergence. As one media analyst put it last week: "Everybody is now in competition with everyone else."

Five years after the tech bubble burst, puncturing momentum in the process, media companies are charging full steam ahead.

Old-school media mogul Rupert Murdoch is enthusing like a 12-year-old about Internet companies he's instructed News Corp. to gobble up. He told Wall Streeters two weeks ago that he expects his company's revenues from broadband to skyrocket fivefold in the next five years.

He's hardly alone.

Once-uptight telco types are loosening their ties and ordering up original video material; Hollywood studio chieftains are waffling on about narrowing or collapsing windows so as to better squeeze out ancillary revenues; exhibitors are digitizing at the rate of 300 moviehouses a month.

Just last week things really heated up.

Google said it would provide free wireless high-speed Internet access in San Francisco, allowing users to bypass cable or phone hookups they traditionally pay for in favor of wi-fi links. eBay and Microsoft are planning similar forays.

Yahoo's Santa Monica-based media unit started hiring former TV producers to help inch the company into the content creation biz.

And this is just in the U.S.

Parts of Asia and western Europe are ahead of the game in several key areas.

The South Koreans can do all kinds of high-speed Internet acrobatics while traveling on their bullet trains. The country is building a so-called "ubiquitous" city outside Seoul where even the doorjams will be digitized. Europeans enjoy all kinds of audio and visual data on their mobiles, and they have hardly penetrated Stateside. Consolidation in various industries is picking up, usually a prelude to expanding high-tech services.

